PolyU · Master of Design · SD5412

Advanced Service Design Methods and Tools

談 Michael Tam · 31 Aug 2026

— // my_belief —

The hardest decisions fail when people agree on answers before they agree on the question.



談 Michael Tam

Founder of Joyventure. Formerly IBM's first Global Design Principal from Hong Kong — one of 73 worldwide — and Chief Product Officer at Preface.

— // impact_made —

Service design → business value

USD 150M+

50+ enterprise engagements

IBM commercial impact

NZD 183M+

Passenger credits reconnected

Air New Zealand

79,000

Employees in one return-to-office redesign

Salesforce

880+

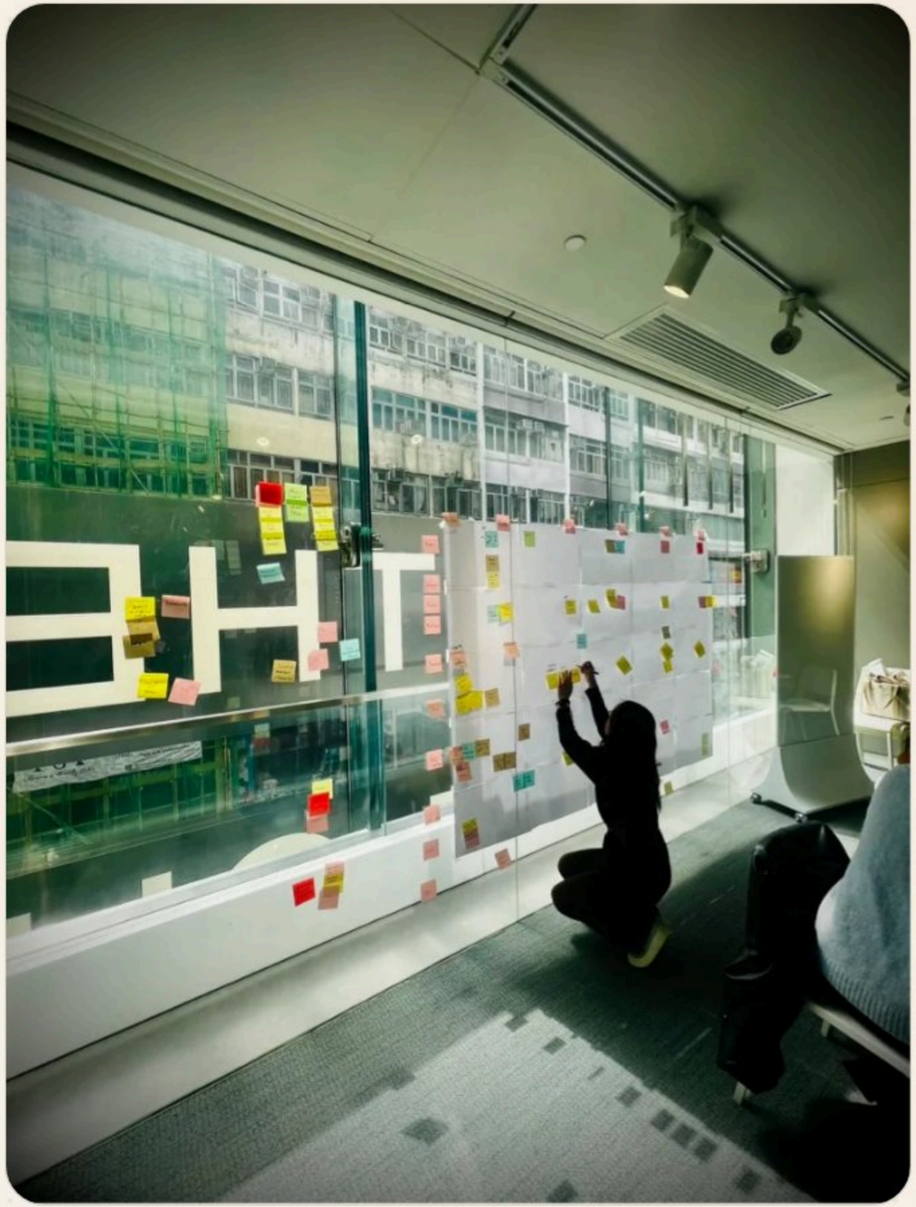
People upskilled · 330+ workshop hours

IBM EDT practice

— // organisational_debt —

What it costs when the assumed process and the real one drift apart.

At Preface, the undocumented service concealed business logic in pricing, bundling, and scheduling. Service design sessions surfaced those debts before a line of code was written. Rebuilding scheduling made it 60% faster, with a projected 40% reduction in monthly support calls.



— // why_this_subject_exists —

Running the method is now cheap. Choosing it is not.

Synthesis that took a week takes an afternoon. When execution gets cheap, the value moves upstream — into intent, and into judgment.

This subject is about the decisions the method cannot make for you.

INTENT

Clarify the objective, frame the right problem, and decide what is worth building.

JUDGMENT

Separate good from merely plausible by weighing evidence, trade-offs, risk, and consequence.

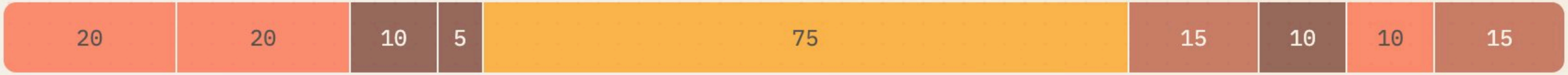
EXECUTION

Turn choices into reality. AI lowers the cost of production; it does not decide what deserves to exist.

— // rundown_of_today —

Three hours of writing, thinking, and sharing

Most of today you are standing at a wall with a Sharpie. Laptops stay closed unless I say otherwise.



09:30	Open	20 min
09:50	What service design is	20 min
10:10	The wall	10 min
10:20	Studio brief	5 min
10:25	Studio	75 min
11:40	Reflection I	15 min
11:55	Collective critique	10 min
12:05	Assessment metrics	10 min
12:15	Reflection II	15 min

— // SD5412_overview —

Thirteen sessions. Five blocks.

A

Foundation and Frame

S01–02

What is actually happening, and what are we being asked to do

B

Research at Scale

S03–05

Hearing the right people, and making the evidence mean something

C

Blueprinting as Systems Thinking

S06–09

Front to back, and what it is worth

D

Co-design for Organisational Change

S10–12

The room, and what happens after it

E

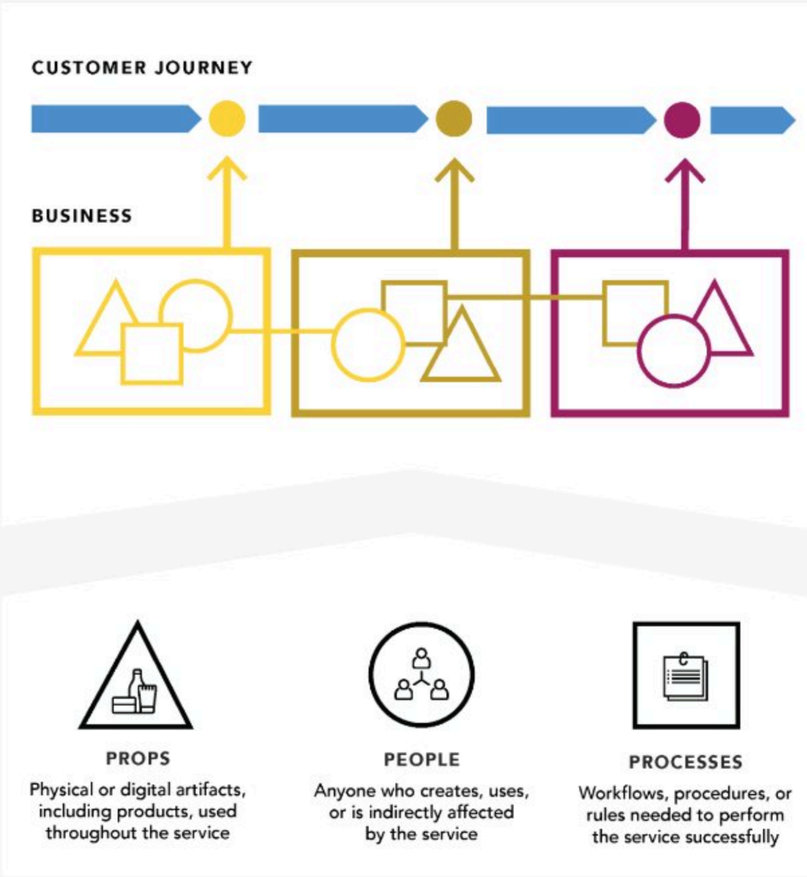
Final Studio Critique

S13

Practitioners review your work

— // what_service_design_is —

The most misunderstood capability in the room.



Credit: Sarah Gibbsons @ NNGroup.com

— // a_practitioner_view —

What a service designer actually does

Marcus Kirsch, 2026

“They see things no one sees, or that people stopped talking about. They look at places others do not consider to be part of the context.”

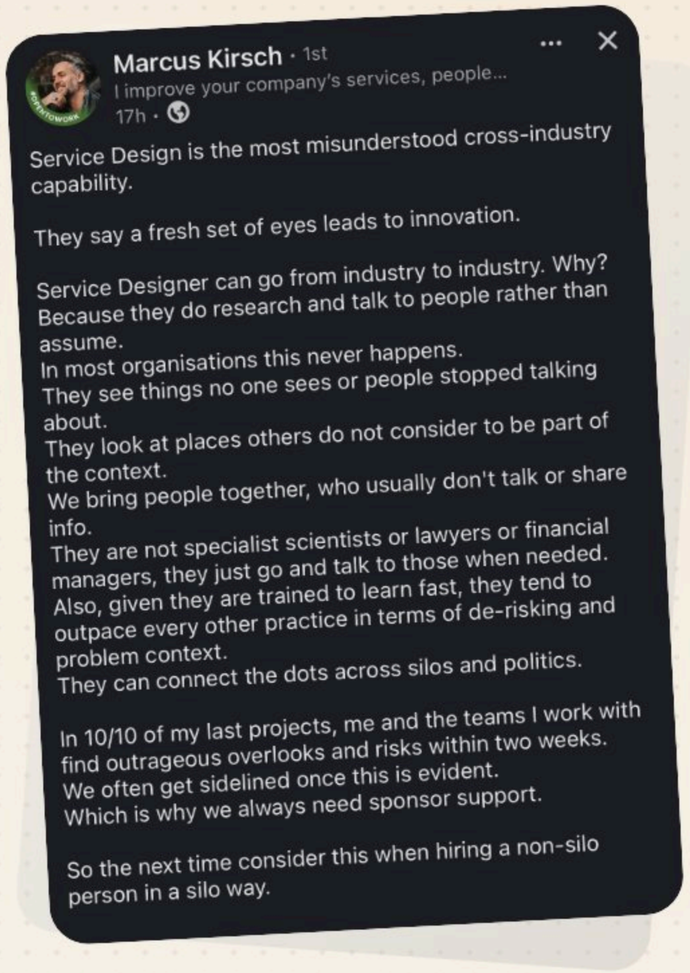
“In 10 out of 10 of my last projects, we found overlooks and risks within two weeks.”

— // reality_check —

The sting in the tail

Marcus Kirsch, 2026

“We often get sidelined once it is evident. Which is why we always need sponsor support.”



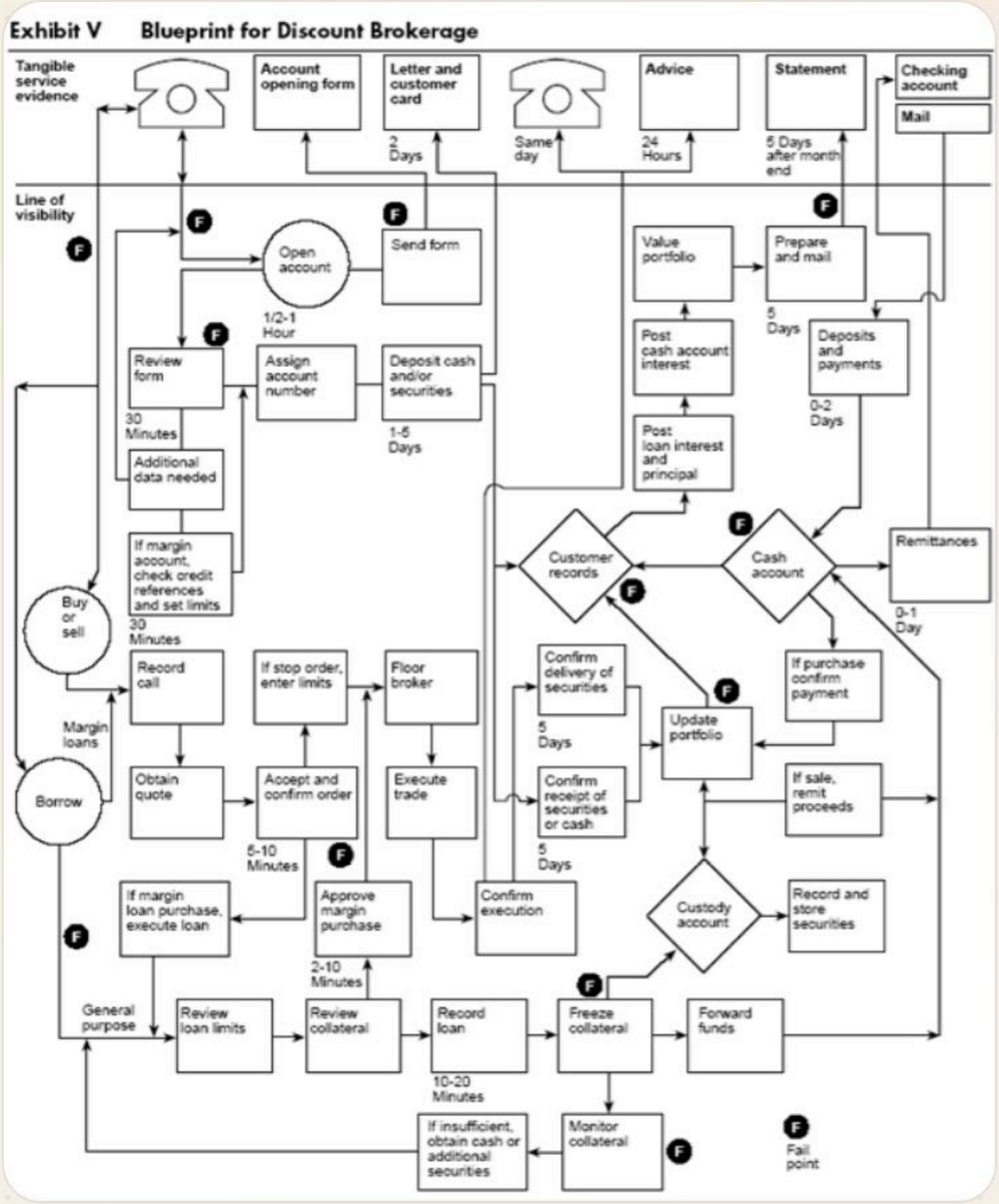
We will learn how to navigate this challenge in S05, S08, and S12.

— // academic_origin —

1982

The blueprint was born in a marketing journal.

G. Lynn Shostack proposed the service blueprint in the European Journal of Marketing in 1982, later captured in Harvard Business Review, before design claimed it. It was a management tool first.



– // the_truth –

Every organisation runs two realities at once.

1. The one that is documented — the one people can see.
2. The one that actually moves work.
3. Advanced practice begins in the gap.

– // starbucks_demo –

Order → barista → POS → inventory → supply chain → app and loyalty

One visible moment depends on a chain of actions, roles and systems.



– // the_layers –

Frontstage. Backstage. Enabling.

Customer Journey →

LINE OF INTERACTION

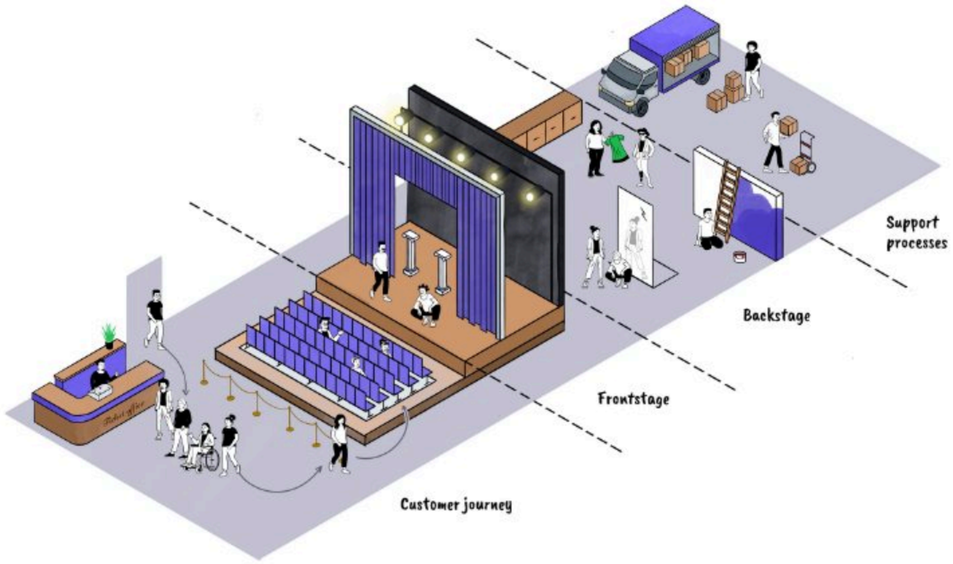
01 **Frontstage**
Order · Barista
The customer can see it.

LINE OF VISIBILITY

02 **Backstage**
POS · Inventory
Delivery work the customer cannot see.

LINE OF INTERNAL INTERACTION

03 **Enabling**
Supply Chain · App & Loyalty
People, policies, data and systems that make both possible.



— // where_judgment_lives —

Three ways of knowing

"Wicked Problems in Design Thinking", R. Buchanan, 1992

Neo-positivist

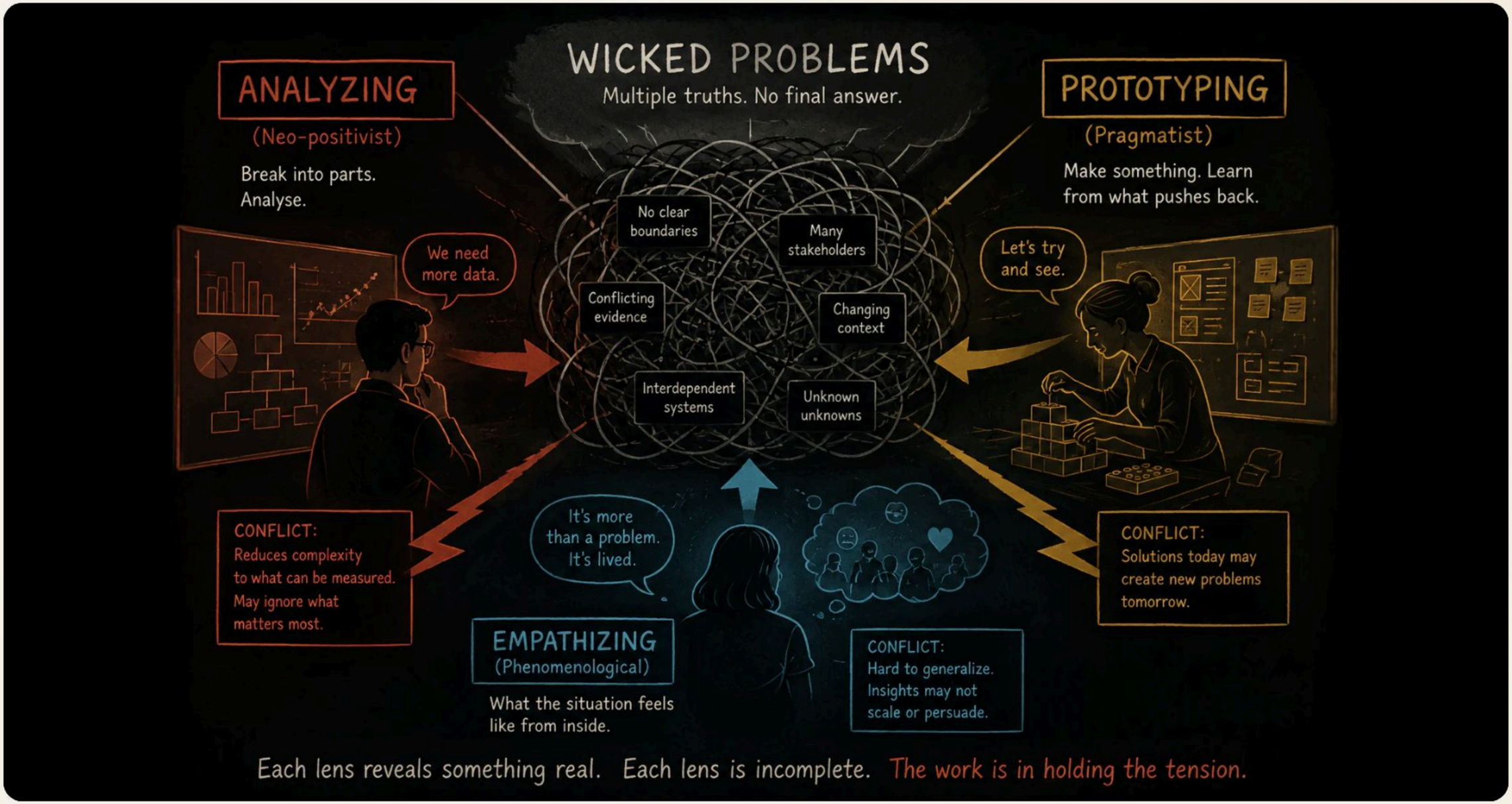
Break into parts. Analyse.

Pragmatist

Make something. Learn from what pushes back.

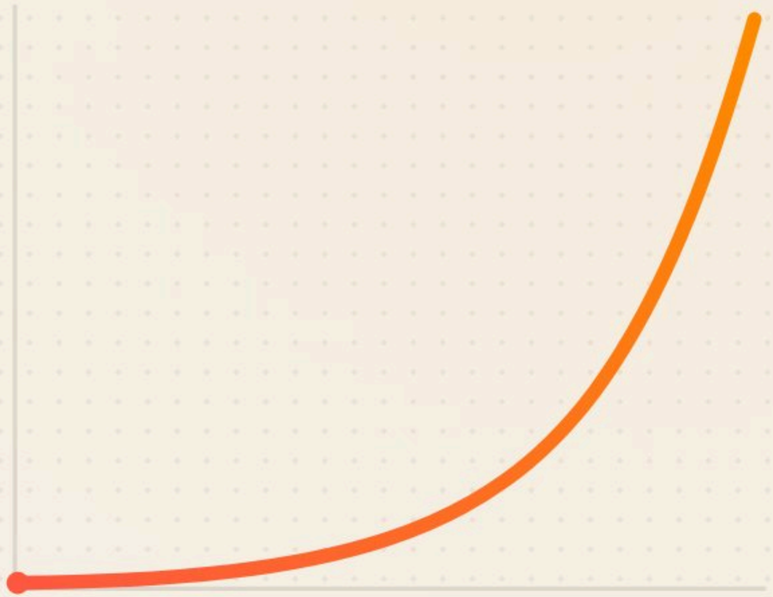
Phenomenological

What the situation feels like from inside.


WICKED PROBLEMS
Multiple truths. No final answer.
ANALYZING
(Neo-positivist)
Break into parts.
Analyse.
PROTOTYPING
(Pragmatist)
Make something. Learn
from what pushes back.
No clear boundaries
Many stakeholders
Conflicting evidence
Changing context
Interdependent systems
Unknown unknowns
We need more data.
Let's try and see.
It's more than a problem. It's lived.
CONFLICT:
Reduces complexity to what can be measured. May ignore what matters most.
CONFLICT:
Solutions today may create new problems tomorrow.
EMPATHIZING
(Phenomenological)
What the situation feels like from inside.
CONFLICT:
Hard to generalize. Insights may not scale or persuade.
Each lens reveals something real. Each lens is incomplete. The work is in holding the tension.

— // what_ai_changes —

Add AI to a service nobody has mapped honestly and you scale the mess.



— // the_chain —

Judgment lives in the joins.

A claim that cannot be traced backwards is an assertion — and it is marked as one.

01
Intent
What are we solving for, and whose goal is it?

→

02
Evidence
Who did we hear from, and who was easy to leave out?

→

03
Insight
What does the evidence mean, stated so it can be tested?

→

04
Criteria
By what weighted considerations will we judge our concepts?

→

05
Solution
What are we proposing, front to back?

→

06
Invalidation
What would prove this wrong? What did we kill?

→

07
Landing
What changed, and how does it enter an organisation?

— // our_anchoring_questions —

The wall

Eight questions · 1–3

1. *When you can only map one journey, which one would you choose — and who loses because of it?*
2. *What conditions have to be true before you can start something? And what do you do when they are not?*
3. *Who do you leave out of a meeting or discussion, and what does that decision cost you later?*

— // our_anchoring_questions —

The wall

Eight questions · 4–6

4. *Two credible sources disagree. Which one do you believe, and what would change your mind?*
5. *Your design artefact or output is beautiful, but nobody acted on it or used it. What was actually missing?*
6. *The person who is most senior or most authoritative in the room is wrong. What would you do?*

— // our_anchoring_questions —

The wall

Eight questions · 7–8

7. *What would you have to measure for a CFO to fund your idea or vision, and what would you refuse to measure?*

8. *The AI model produced results in four minutes. What in your work is still yours?*

— // in_30_seconds —

Choose one.
Do not choose the easy one.

— // grounded_in_your_own_experiences —

Write. Sign. Pin.

Five minutes · A5 · no discussion

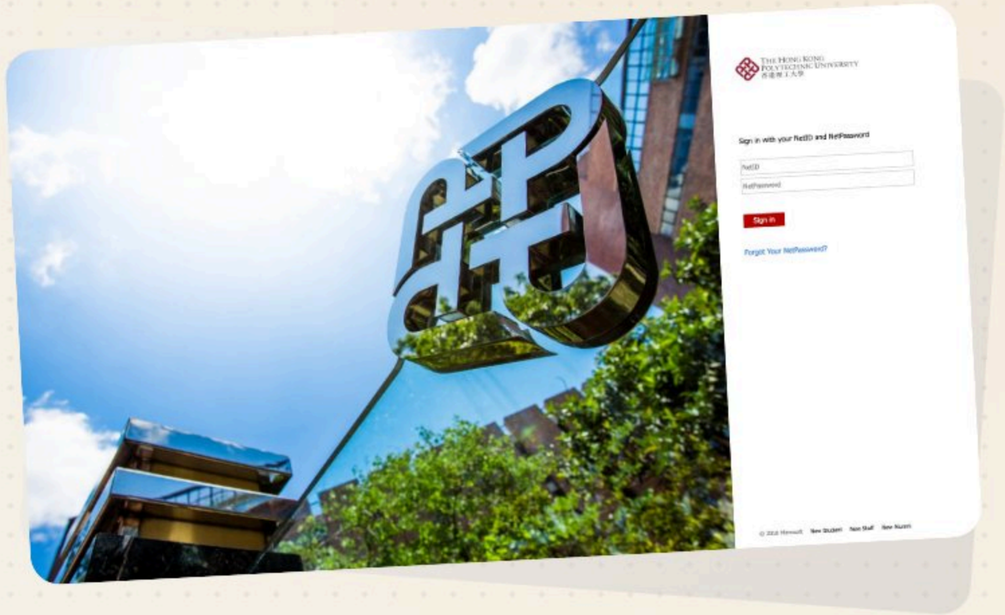
In S13, we will reopen this card and see how much our thinking evolved



— // when_services_get_complex —

Well designed, then messy.

Starbucks showed you what the layers are. PolyU enrolment shows you what happens when they do not hold.



— // studio_subject —

Map your experience of PolyU enrolment and add/drop.

Alternative: opening a Hong Kong bank account.

Portals, emails, WhatsApp groups and ‘just go and ask the office’ may all belong to the trail.

— // michael's_technique —

The Honest Map

75 minutes · five rounds

1. Two colours. Keep the gap visible.
2. Devices away.
3. Follow the **Studio Runner** for instructions & timekeeping

– // reflection_1 –

Reflection I

15 min · silent · individual · before critique

1. What did we decide — and what did we decide against?
2. What was the reasoning? Not the outcome. The reasoning.
3. What would have changed my mind?

— // think_collectively —

Critique the gap, not the drawing.

15 min · open floor

1. *Which gap changes how you understand the service?*
2. *Which role is doing work nobody planned for?*
3. *Which layer holds most divergence — and what is the evidence?*

— // course_assessment_metrics —

Frame. Decide. Prove.

60% team project · **40%** individual **Logbook** *(via weekly reflections)*

FRAME Intent · Evidence · Insight

Did you understand the real problem, not just the brief as written?

DECIDE Criteria · Solution

Did you make a defensible choice, and can you explain why?

PROVE Invalidation · Landing

Did you test it honestly, including where it fell short?

Distinction

Holds under challenge. Asked 'why?' at any point, you answer with evidence — and can name what would have changed your mind.

Proficient

Holds, but breaks at one or two points. Reasoning present, partly assumed.

Developing

Asserted rather than shown. The steps are there; they are not connected.

Not yet

Steps missing, or the chain runs backwards — solution first, evidence retrofitted.

– // the_contract –

The logbook, the briefs and AI

The logbook

Handwritten A5 card after every session. Photograph it. Upload before next class. Thirteen entries build your individual report.

Your brief

Real Hong Kong organisations. Brief providers join the 12 October panel. The panel questions and advises. Michael marks.

AI

Use it openly. How much you use is never assessed. Only your reasoning about it is.

— // this_subject_and_the_studio —

Two subjects, deliberately paired.

You can carry both. The programme is built that way.

This subject · SD5412

Outcome-driven and enterprise-scale. Every method ends in a decision somebody is accountable for.

The Studio · by Dr. PARK

Exploratory and observational, at a different intensity.

— // reflection_2 —

Reflection II

15 min · handwritten A5 · upload before the next session

1. What do I think differently now than I did at 09:30?
2. What did I do or say today that I would do differently?
3. What can I still not answer?
4. *Then: one line, signed, for the wall — One thing I now know I do not know.*

— // homework —

Bring to S02

01 · a real brief

One real brief you have been given — a project brief, a job description, a client email, an assignment. Anything where somebody asked you to do something. We are going to take one apart.

02 · One sentence: a service that failed you this year.

03 · A pen you actually like. You will be handwriting a card at the end of every session for six weeks.

On Friday you receive project briefs
— Hong Kong enterprises have given us real problems they have not solved.

— // SD5412_Session_1 —

Two systems.
Start with the gap.



SCAN FOR PULSE